This Opioid Alternative Is Fueling an Addiction Crisis

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AI Executive Summary

1. Core Thesis

Kratom, an herbal product gaining popularity as a non-prescription alternative to opioids for pain relief and energy, is currently facing intense scrutiny and legal challenges in the U.S. following thousands of reported fatal overdoses and widespread addiction concerns. While proponents argue it should remain accessible as a dietary supplement akin to coffee, public health officials and advocatesâ€”such as the mother of a deceased victimâ€”are pushing for bans due to severe risks, including interactions with common medications like antidepressants. The debate remains split between federal hesitation following previous lobbying backlashes and local legislative action, such as the unanimous Idaho Falls ban on all kratom products, creating a complex regulatory landscape centered on natural leaf versus synthetic 7-OH potency compounds.

2. Key Arguments & Data

- **Health Risks vs. Utility:** Kratom contains psychoactive compounds (mitragynine and 7-hydroxymitragynine or 7-OH) that bind to the same brain receptors as opioids, making it effective for chronic pain relief but highly addictive for some users.
- **Overdose Statistics:** Between 2020 and 2024, the CDC recorded more than 5,000 fatal overdoses involving kratom. Autopsies frequently list "kratom intoxication" as a cause of death, though it is often co-ingested with other substances (benadryl, antidepressants, opioids).
- **The Synthetic vs. Natural Divide:** Companies like Happy Hippo distinguish between traditional plain leaf powder and synthetic 7-OH products. The latter are produced in labs, are significantly more potent, and are associated with a dramatic increase in severe withdrawal symptoms and addiction reports; natural kratom proponents argue 7-OH is the primary driver of recent health issues and calls for stricter regulation of concentrated synthetics rather than banning all leaf products.

- **Lack of Research:** Medical officials note there is insufficient research into kratom's specific interaction with common prescription medications (e.g., antidepressants, benadryl) or the identification of a toxic dose.
- **Regulatory Landscape:**
  - **Local Action:** The Idaho Falls City Council voted unanimously to ban all kratom products in July 2024, joining a trend of localities banning the substance even where states do not.
  - **Federal Stance:** The DEA is currently considering placing high-potency 7-OH kratom products under Schedule I (equating them with heroin). Previous federal regulation attempts in 2016 were thwarted by industry lobbying groups like the American Kratom Association.
- **Industry Response:** Major distributors like Happy Hippo ship over 100 kilograms of kratom daily and market their product as a dietary supplement, wellness tool, or "natural" energy source to avoid being classified as a drug.

3. Actionable Takeaways

- **For Consumers:** Be aware that many products available online or in convenience stores are unregulated; differentiate between plain leaf powder (often marketed as supplements) and synthetic or high-concentration 7-OH products (marketed as gummies, seltzers, etc.) if concerned about potency and addiction risks.
- **For Public Health/Regulatory Stakeholders:** Prioritize research into kratom's interaction with common OTC medications to mitigate accidental interactions for users taking antidepressants or antihistamines alongside the supplement. Expect further localized bans as cities adopt municipal regulations even where states have not yet legislated.
- **For Investors/Business Leaders:** Monitor potential regulatory shifts under FDA/DEA guidance regarding synthetic concentrates; companies selling kratom gummies, seltzers, or concentrated extracts face higher legal risk in jurisdictions following the Idaho Falls model compared to those selling natural leaf powder.

Full Transcript

Over the past few years, an herbal product has been exploding in popularity. It's called Kratom. It's made from the leaf of a tree that grows in Southeast Asia, but you can buy it in most states across the U.S. Kratom can be bought almost everywhere in gas stations, online, and convenience stores. Our colleague Sumathi Reddy writes about health and medicine. People say it can act like caffeine in small doses. It's like, you know, it just gives you more energy. Maybe it makes you more alert. It can be more sedative and have a different effect. So there are some people who say that Kratom is a great product for pain relief. In June, Kratom was the subject of a city council meeting in Idaho. When this back injury is when I flares up, I can barely move. It is totally incapacitated for that time. But with Kratom, I can at least function.

That's Chris Diodes, who runs a cratum business. He was in the city of Idaho Falls to share why cratum has been helpful for him. And he was wearing a t-shirt that read, cratum saves lives. And he spoke about how plain leaf cratum has kind of made his life bearable, particularly with a recurring back injury. People who used to take opioids also say it's like a good sort of alternative. The reason Chris was testifying is that the Idaho Falls City Council was considering a citywide cratum ban. Some doctors and public health officials say cratum can have serious health risks, that it can be addictive and serve as a gateway drug. There have also been thousands of deaths associated with cratum. One person speaking in favor of banning cratum was Tia Rostici. Craig had killed my daughter. Now I'm a little straighter. I think sometimes I'm not substance. It was crazy. It was this product that you can buy anywhere and that's marketed as natural and safe. And this is something she says over and over again. A lot of the parents do. The sort of disbelief, like why, how could my child have died from something that's just like available like a piece of candy. The reality is the parents often do not know what Craig is. Young people sit on store shelves and assume it must be safe.

In the aftermath of the opioid epidemic, Kratom has become a multi-billion-dollar industry that's largely unregulated. And that city council meeting in

Idaho captures a growing nationwide debate. Should Kratom be legal? Welcome to The Journal, our show about money, business, and power. I'm Jessica Mendoza. It's Monday, August 17th. Coming up on the show, the fight over Kratom. Usually, Kratom comes in powder form.

It can kind of look like matcha, although it has a more bitter taste. These days, though, it comes in the form of gummies, seltzers, tablets. They're all kinds of products. Cratom kind of grew in popularity as opioids were becoming a big problem. So doctors, you know, kind of stopped prescribing opioids and people needed something for pain relief. And so some people started turning to cratom, which apparently can be pretty effective for chronic pain. Cratom has two key psychoactive compounds. They're called metrogenine and 70H. They both bind to the same brain receptors as opioids. That's why many people say cratum is great for pain relief. But it becomes addictive for some people, and you need larger and larger doses. And then there started being these newer products that were more potent, which were causing even more addiction. And some people who wanted to stop taking these things found out that the withdrawal symptoms can be quite severe.

In recent years, the cratum market has been growing with new products that are highly concentrated and sometimes made synthetically. Medical officials say these stronger products have dramatically increased the number of people reporting withdrawal symptoms and seeking help for addiction. In June, Sumathi flew to Idaho to hear from both sides of the cratum debate. While she was there, she visited Tia Rustici at home. The woman whose daughter, Kylie, died of a cratum overdose. They spoke in the backyard. So she would, she was very outgoing, very social. She grew up here in this house? We moved here in 2013. So Collie was a 23 year old. She was attending online college. She wanted to be a forensic accountant. She was diagnosed with two chronic conditions, sort of in the later years of high school, maybe in her early 20s. So she dealt with a lot of pain from those conditions.

Kylie Rusty C's pain was debilitating enough that she needed to see a pain management specialist. She also had depression and was taking an antidepressant. At one point, she moved in with her grandmother. And so

what happened once she was at Grandma's? I went there the week before to visit and we went to the movies and we went out to lunch. And then we just had a great visit and she was just seemed like just revitalized, I guess. And we were texting and the night before. Did she seem in good spirits? No, no. But it's hard to tell from the heart. Tia Rustici didn't know that besides her antidepressant and some over-the-counter medications, her daughter had also started using cratum. She kind of kept it a little secretive, but she was taking the powder only. And I guess it just sort of ramped up where she started taking more and more and more.

On a Sunday evening in March, Kylie Rustici was found dead on her bedroom floor. There were a few bags of natural leaf cratum powder on her dresser. She had overdosed. An autopsy report listed the cause of death as cratum intoxication. When they said cratum, what did you...? I didn't know. I started googling what's cratum. So, and then the more I found out, the more shocked I was. Reports to poison control centers involving cratum have been on the rise. And between 2020 and 2024, the CDC recorded more than 5,000 fatal overdoses in which cratum was detected. Though, Sumathi says it's not always clear if cratum is the sole cause of death. In many cases, there are other substances involved. I mean, sometimes, you know, it's something like heroin or fentanyl, but other times it's something like benadryl or an antidepressant.

So there are questions about, well, does creative interact with some of these other things that people routinely take? Like a lot of people take antidepressants or benadryl or antihistamines. So is that raising the health risks? And we don't really know, because that research hasn't been done. What about Tia Rustici? What has she decided to do? So she's become quite an advocate for creative bands. There's a bunch of parents that she's become close with. Some of them have started organizations and they kind of just go and testify at every hearing that they can. Like at the city council meeting in Idaho Falls, who are anti-cratom advocates up against? During her trip to Idaho, Sumithi also went to visit one of the biggest cratom companies in the U.S. It's called Happy Hippo. The company runs a 20,000 square foot facility with colorful signs that say things like, live happy. So Happy Hippo It's a very cheerful place. They definitely marked themselves as like a wellness company. And one of the big things they do is distribute

freedom. While she was there, Sumathi met CEO Chris Diotis, who had spoken at that same Idaho Falls City Council meeting. Well, I want to hear both about the company as well as your story. So I don't know which one you want to start with. Yeah, I'll start with mine. Chris describes himself as like a fitness bro.

So he had a lot of injuries, just from sports and exercise. And in 2006, he had a bad knee injury. I really got a knee injury playing a football game. Mm-hmm. The silly football game. It was on Memorial Day weekend. Tackle football. Chris says he was prescribed Percocet, an opioid. And after about five or six months of taking it, he started to feel like he was building a dependence on the drug. And being their source school 20-year-old that he was... I was looking for alternatives. And I found Craydon, and I tried it. And I was just like, wow, this does really dull. Because at the time, it was probably mild to moderate paint. It wasn't the intense, acute paint coming off post-op. I was like, this is really good. It doesn't pair me, either. And I was like, there's really something with this.

Chris still uses Kratom today to treat chronic pain from a back injury. He founded Happy Hippo in 2013. These days, the company ships out more than 100 kilograms of Kratom a day. It specializes in plain leaf Kratom powder and capsules, but also sells things like Kratom gummies and taffy. Their products are, you know, they're marketed in a very sort of friendly way. They're very colorful and they have cool flavors and stuff. And he says that, you know, his clients or customers are, you know, There's a very wellness, fitness sort of driven demographic. Like a lot of middle-aged moms taking this for energy or to improve their sleep or, you know, those kinds of things, wellness type things. But Chris says when it comes to Kratom, there's a line he won't cross. You know, one of the things he stressed a lot when I was there was that they've taken a sort of hard line stance against manufacturing products that are like 708. 708.

one of the psychoactive compounds naturally found in cratum in very trace amounts. And over the last few years, some companies have started focusing on concentrated 7-OH products. They're way more potent than natural cratum. Chris says these products are giving his industry a bad rap. Cratum is closer to a food or dietary supplement or beverage. And 7-OH is

closer to a drug, especially how it's made these days. Once upon a time, the 708 on the market was possibly extracted from cradum leaf, but the proliferation of it now, it's all just made of a lab. These 708s and sort of stronger products are definitely causing addiction and other health issues. When you talk about natural cradum, there is a little more of a divide. Some of the people I've talked to will say that they see problems with 708s, but they also see it with natural cradum. So they would support a broader ban.

But others will say, I think if we solve the issue with 708 and the stronger products, we'll be okay. In the end, the city of Idaho falls voted unanimously to ban all cratum products. That ban went into effect in July. That city joins a growing list of places in the U.S. that are cracking down on cratum. And while a few states have banned it statewide, a lot of this action is happening from town to town. Idaho does not have an all cratum ban, they considered one. But because some of the states are not acting, there are a lot of cities and towns who are acting on their own. And Idaho Falls is one. Why is this being discussed, you know, at the local and state level? I mean, isn't this something that could or should be regulated at the federal level? There have been attempts to regulate Crayton before. The most serious one was back in 2016. And there was such intense backlash and opposition that the federal government sort of backed down.

A lot of that backlash and opposition was coming from lobbying groups. One group in particular, the American Cratom Association, has played a major role in keeping Cratom on store shelves. They have a consumer protection act they kind of drafted and they give to a lot of the states that introduce these acts. And so it's various things to like have a minimum age for people who can buy this stuff to have labels that reflect what's in it and the strength and the dose. to be more clear on the labels, like, is a 708? You know, what's in here? And some other things. And there's a number of states that they've been able to get the Regulation Act passed in. While the American Cratum Association lobbies to keep cratum accessible, it supports banning stronger products like 708. Federal regulation could echo that line of thinking. The Drug Enforcement Administration is now considering placing those stronger products under Schedule 1.

which basically means they'd be considered as dangerous as heroin. What are you watching for in terms of how this debate develops, how the regulation evolves? You know, I think one of the things is that we don't know a lot about cradum and how it impacts our health. I mean, there really isn't much research. This is a problem we had with cannabis, too, right? It was illegal, so we had never done any research on it. I'm hoping this will lead to Consumers, like, understanding what this is better. Like, what is this? Is it dangerous? Can it interact with the antidepressants? You know, what's the highest dose we can take? What's the toxic dose? We don't have answers to any of these questions. So hopefully, hopefully we'll get some answers. That's all for today, Monday, August 17th. The Journal is a co-production of Spotify and the Wall Street Journal. If you like our show, follow us on Spotify or wherever you get your podcasts.

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